

Figure 4.2 The vocabulary around Agile requirements can be a little confusing at times.

How did we get ourselves into this predicament? All we really want to do is describe what we think our users need. We want to express ourselves in a way that business stakeholders can understand, so that they can validate our understanding, contribute, and provide feedback as early as possible. We want to be able to describe what our users need in a way that makes it easier to build and deliver software that meets these needs.

The terms we use are intended to simplify discussion around user requirements. In essence, we're trying to do two things:

- Deliver tangible, visible value to the business at regular intervals
- Get regular feedback so we know if we're going in the right direction

The way we describe and organize the requirements should support these goals. The various ways different teams organize and structure stories, epics, features, and so forth are simply ways to decompose higher-level requirements into manageable sizes, describe them in terms that users can understand, and allow them to provide feedback at each level. There are many perfectly legitimate ways to do this, and what works best for your team will depend on the size and complexity of your project and on the background and culture of your organization and team members.

For the sake of simplicity and consistency, let's step through the vocabulary we'll use throughout the rest of this book. We'll mainly be dealing with four terms: *capabilities*, *features*, *user stories*, and *examples* (see figure 4.3).

I introduced these concepts in the previous chapter, but here's a quick refresher:

- *Capabilities* give users or stakeholders the ability to realize some business goal or perform some useful task. A capability represents the ability to do something; it doesn't depend on a particular implementation. For example, "the ability to book a flight" is a capability.
- *Features* represent software functionality that you build to support these capabilities. "Book a flight online" would be a feature.
- When you build and deliver these features, you can use *user stories* to break down the work into more manageable chunks and to plan and organize your work.